transparent way, and to do all this in a measured but steady way so that the system could adjust. As I will explain, this is broadly how we dealt with issues ranging from inflation management to resolving distressed loans. Throughout, our attempt was to institutionalize processes so that they would be both predictable and enduring. India is becoming a large middle income country, too complex and varied to be controlled centrally. The government will need to withdraw from occupying the commanding heights of the economy, confining itself to providing public goods and the governing framework, and leaving economic activity to the people. To harness their collective energy, India will need many such reforms in the years to come if it is to grow rapidly in a sustainable and equitable way.

My speeches were an essential part of the stabilization and reform process, allowing me to explain the rationale for change to investors and the public, flag the building blocks of the reform, and draw in opinion leaders into the debate while the specific regulations were being drafted. The additional value of describing what we intended to do and delivering on it repeatedly was that it allowed the RBI to get credit for the intended reform from the market at the time of announcement, much before the time of delivery. This could prove crucial if markets became volatile again. Also, many speeches tried to educate the broader public on the underlying finance and economics. If someone got drawn by a speech into learning more, that was one more step towards spreading financial and economic literacy – I had what every teacher wants, a national platform, one I tried to use effectively and responsibly.

I also used my speeches to partly fulfil another important role the RBI has, that of managing macroeconomic risk for the country. This objective, as we will see, led to speeches that proved more controversial, perhaps because I was speaking outside the usual areas